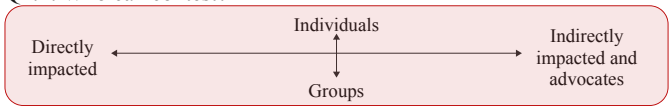
QCD: Questions for Contestable Design

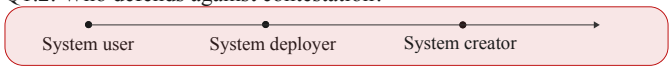
Contestation Mechanism

Parties involved

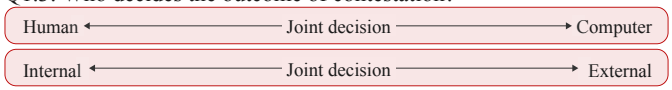
Q1.1: Who can contest?



Q1.2: Who defends against contestation?

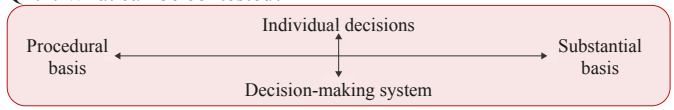


Q1.3: Who decides the outcome of contestation?



Review process

Q1.4: What can be contested?



Q1.5: What information will be used in the review?



Q1.6: What are the possible outcomes?



Accessibility of Contestation

- Q2.1: What are the costs to participating in contestability? Who can afford these costs?
- Q2.2: How much effort is required from the impacted parties?
- Q2.3: How much time do impacted parties have to prepare their arguments and to contest?
- Q2.4: How long does it take before decisions are made?

Communication of Information

- Q3.1: Do impacted parties know that (a) a decision impacting them was made (b) with algorithmic software, (c) that they can contest?
- Q3.2: How can the steps in the contestation process be communicated clearly?
- Q3.3: What is the technical expertise of contesting parties?
- Q3.4: What do contesting parties know about organizational policies, decision-making procedures, relevant legislation, etc.?
- Q3.5: What are the contesting individuals' preexisting beliefs, experiences, and perceptions of the decision-making system and algorithmic software?
- Q3.6: Is both technical and non-technical information clear and easy-to-understand?
- Q3.7: How does the presentation of information influence contesting parties and their motivation to contest?
- Q3.8: How can contesting parties communicate with technical experts, if needed?

System Context

- Q4.1: What power dynamics might exist between the system and impacted parties? How does this impact contestability?
- Q4.2: What conflicts of interest might impact the outcome of contestation?
- Q4.3: What are the stakes of the decision? How might it influence contestability?

Participation in Design

- Q5.1: How much time and effort does it take for impacted parties to provide participate in design?
- Q5.2: How can impacted parties participate in design when working alongside designers who are more knowledgeable about the system?
- Q5.3: How are different groups of impacted parties, particularly minority groups, represented during system development?

Decision-Making Quality

- Q6.1: What design and evaluation practices can align software system behaviour with real-world use cases?
- Q6.2: How can the system make decisions that are consistent, reproducible, and fair, particularly for marginalized communities?
- Q6.3: How can design decisions be made transparent and traceable?
- Q6.4: How well do software users, such as decision-makers, understand the algorithmic software and sociotechnical system components?
- Q6.5: Do software users and human decision-makers have actual influence on the outcome of decisions?
- Q6.6: How could the feedback from contestation inform how systems are developed and deployed?